

Polyvinylidene Fluoride (PVDF) in Energy Storage

From Incumbent Binder to Next-Generation Functional Material

Department of Chemical Engineering

Course: CLL767 - Structures & Properties of Polymers

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Outline

- 1 Introduction & Polymer Science
- 2 Quantified Properties for Batteries
- 3 Advanced Characterization Methods
- 4 Applications: Binders & Separators
- 5 Sustainability Crisis & Alternatives
- 6 Future of PVDF & Market Analysis
- 7 Conclusions & Future Outlook

What is Polyvinylidene Fluoride (PVDF)?

A Critical Fluoropolymer

- High-performance, semi-crystalline thermoplastic fluoropolymer
- Synthesized from vinylidene fluoride (VDF): $-\text{[CH}_2\text{-CF}_2\text{]}_n$
- **Key feature:** Highly polar C-F bonds → large dipole moment
- Exceptional chemical resistance, thermal stability ($>400^\circ\text{C}$), UV resistance

Critical Role in Energy Storage

Dual Function in Lithium-Ion Batteries:

- 1 Industry-standard **polymeric binder** for electrodes
- 2 High-performance **battery separator** material

The Key to PVDF: Crystalline Polymorphism

α -Phase (Alpha)

- Most common & thermodynamically stable
- Forms when crystallized from melt
- **Conformation:** TGTG' (Trans-Gauche)
- Dipoles cancel → **non-polar**
- Used in standard processing

β -Phase (Beta)

- Most technologically significant
- Forms via stretching or solution-casting
- **Conformation:** TTTT (all-trans)
- All C-F dipoles align → **highly polar**
- Piezoelectric & ferroelectric properties

Performance Impact

β -dominant PVDF binder: **185 mAh/g capacity & 98% retention** vs. α -phase: 71.6% retention after 50 cycles

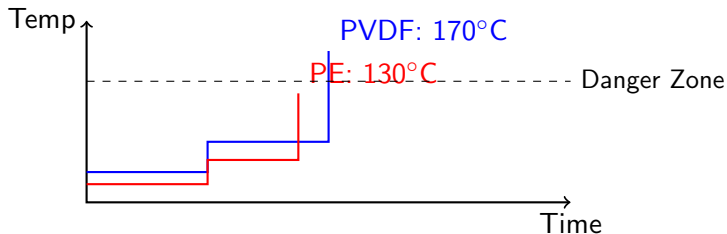
Key Thermal Properties

Glass Transition (T_g)

- **Value:** -35 to -40°C
- Far below battery operating temp
- Amorphous regions stay **flexible**
- Accommodates volume changes without cracking

Melting Temperature (T_m)

- **Value:** 165-175°C
- **Critical safety advantage!**
- PE/PP separators melt at ~130°C
- PVDF's higher T_m prevents catastrophic shorts during thermal runaway



The Master Property: Crystallinity

Percent Crystallinity (%)

- Typical PVDF: 50-70% crystalline
- Battery grades: engineered from 14% to 32%
- **Must balance:** strength, adhesion, electrolyte uptake

Decomposition Temperature

- **Onset:** $>400^{\circ}\text{C}$ (TGA data)
- Electrodes dried at $\sim 130^{\circ}\text{C}$ (NMP evaporation)
- **Wide processing window** ensures polymer integrity

The Crystallinity Trade-Off: Data

Table: Influence of PVDF Crystallinity on Electrode Performance

Property	PVDF 1 (Low)	PVDF 2 (High)	Key Insight
% Crystallinity	14%	32%	Input variable
Adhesion	1.30 N/cm	11.42 N/cm	9× stronger!
Electrolyte Uptake	18.88%	11.3%	Lower = better
LFP Capacity Retention (500c)	136 mAh/g	146 mAh/g	Higher capacity
	64%	82%	18% better

Key Finding

High crystallinity → strong adhesion & controlled swelling → **superior long-term performance**

The Crystallinity Trade-Off: Analysis

Crystallinity → Adhesion

High-crystallinity binder has $\sim 9\times$ **stronger adhesion** due to increased intermolecular interactions between PVDF chains

Crystallinity → Swelling

Low-crystallinity binder has larger amorphous volume → only region electrolyte can penetrate → **higher swelling**

The Non-Obvious Conclusion

Excessive swelling is detrimental!

- High swelling destroys carbon distribution in electrode
- Increases internal resistance → rapid capacity fade
- **Goal:** Optimize crystallinity for adhesion + controlled swelling

Electrochemical Stability

- **The Gold Standard: 0-5 V**
- Stable at low-potential graphite anode (~ 0.1 V)
- Stable at high-voltage cathodes (> 4.3 V)
- One of few polymers with this wide window

Dielectric Constant

- **Value:** $\epsilon = 8.4$ to 12
- High polarity ensures easy wetting
- Aids Li-salt dissociation
- Higher ionic conductivity

The NMP Problem

Limited Solubility: Only dissolves in strong polar aprotic solvents

- **NMP** (N-methyl-2-pyrrolidone)
- DMF, DMAc, DMSO

Why NMP is standard:

- High flash point ($\sim 91^{\circ}\text{C}$)
- Low vapor pressure (safer)
- Up to 99% recyclable

BUT: Classified as **SVHC** & reproductive hazard!

The NMP Challenge: A Sustainability Crisis

Why NMP is a Major Liability

- **Toxicity:** Known developmental & reproductive toxin
- **Environmental:** VOC with strict regulations (EU REACH)
- **Cost:** Expensive + high-energy recovery systems in gigafactories

Solution: Hansen Solubility Parameters (HSP)

Predictive framework for finding green solvents!

HSP decomposes cohesive energy into 3 components: dispersion (δ_D), polar (δ_P), hydrogen bonding (δ_H)

Key Metric: Relative Energy Difference (RED)

- RED < 1.0: High affinity, dissolution likely
- RED > 1.0: Low affinity, won't dissolve

Green Solvent Alternatives: Computational Screening

HSP-Based Screening of 224 Bio-Derived Solvents

Validated PVDF model predicts solubility before costly lab trials!

Table: RED Values for PVDF Solvents

Solvent	RED Value	Assessment
NMP (Reference)	0.50	Excellent solvent
Cyrene (Bio-derived)	0.78	Good solvent
γ -Valerolactone (GVL)	0.80	Good solvent
DMSO	0.88	Good solvent

Key Insight

Cyrene & GVL are viable, non-toxic, sustainable NMP replacements

- Thermodynamically capable of dissolving PVDF
- Bio-derived sources

How Properties Are Measured

Phase & Crystallinity

FTIR: Identifies crystal phase

- Each phase has unique vibrational fingerprint
- β -phase: sharp peak at 838 cm^{-1}

XRD: Quantifies crystallinity

- Sharp peaks = crystalline regions
- Broad halo = amorphous regions
- Integrate areas to calculate %

Thermal Analysis

DSC: Measures heat flow

- T_g appears as small step
- T_m appears as large peak
- Peak area $\rightarrow$ % crystallinity

TGA: Measures mass vs. temp

- Stable plateau up to $>400^\circ\text{C}$
- Sharp drop = decomposition
- Confirms wide processing window

Slurry Rheology (Rotational Rheometer)

Critical for processability! Measures flow behavior:

- 1 **Shear-Thinning:** Viscosity $\downarrow$ at high shear (easy coating)
- 2 **Viscoelastic Gel:** $G' > G''$ at rest (prevents settling)

Mechanical Analysis

Peel Test: Quantifies adhesion

- Pulls coating off foil at constant speed
- Records force required
- Result in N/cm

Electrochemical Analysis

EIS: Impedance spectroscopy

- Measures ionic conductivity
- Probes interface stability
- Degradation shows as $\uparrow$ resistance

Application I: The Electrode Binder

Primary Role: Cohesion & Adhesion

Despite only 2-5% of electrode weight, function is **non-negotiable**:

- **Cohesion:** Binds active material + conductive carbon together
- **Adhesion:** Adheres composite to current collector (Al/Cu foil)

Electrochemical Requirements

- 1 **Stability:** Inert in 0-5 V window
- 2 **Chemical Inertness:** No reaction with electrolyte
- 3 **Controlled Swelling:** Absorb electrolyte for ion transport, but not too much!

The Silicon Anode Problem

Why Silicon?

- Silicon offers **10× higher theoretical capacity** than graphite
- Most promising next-generation anode material

The Catch: Massive Volume Expansion

- **>300% volume expansion** during charging (lithiation)
- Graphite: only $\sim 10\%$ expansion

PVDF's Fundamental Failure

- High modulus makes it **too stiff & brittle**
- Rigid PVDF shell **cannot stretch** → **cracks**
- Leads to electrode pulverization, loss of electrical contact
- **Rapid, irreversible battery failure**

Application II: High-Performance Separator

Dual Functions

- 1 Physical Separation:** Prevents anode-cathode contact (short circuit)
- 2 Ionic Transport:** Microporous structure allows Li^+ ions to pass

Table: PVDF vs. Polyolefin Separators

Property	PE/PP	PVDF	Benefit
T_m	~130-165°C	~ 170°C	Higher safety
Wettability	Poor (non-polar)	Excellent	Lower resistance
Electrolyte Uptake	48-65%	92-95%	Higher capacity
Fabrication	Stretching	Electrospinning	Tunable pores

The Sustainability Crisis: NMP Problem

Toxicity & Regulation

- NMP classified as **Substance of Very High Concern (SVHC)**
- Known **reproductive toxicant** ("may damage unborn child")
- Heavily restricted by EU REACH regulations
- Drives up compliance costs dramatically

The "Aqueous Processing Revolution"

Cost Comparison:

- Water: <\$0.02/L
- NMP: \$1.00-\$3.00/L 50-150× more expensive!

Additional NMP Costs:

- High-energy, high-CAPEX solvent recovery infrastructure
- Energy-intensive drying (high boiling point)
- VOC compliance and environmental regulations

End-of-Life Recycling Crisis

Pyrometallurgy (Burning)

Process: High-temp incineration (600-1600°C)

The Problem:

- PVDF decomposes → releases **HF gas**
- Hydrogen fluoride: highly corrosive & toxic
- Requires costly acid scrubbers
- Can deactivate recovered cathode materials

Hydrometallurgy (Leaching)

Process: Acids dissolve & separate metals

The Problem:

- PVDF's exceptional chemical resistance = **doesn't dissolve**
- Remains as solid contaminant
- Complicates metal salt purification

Future Solution

Green Solvent Direct Recycling: DMSO, DMI, or ethylene glycol to dissolve binder & recover intact cathodes

Alternative Binders: Challenging Assumptions

Common Misconception: PVDF Has Best Adhesion

Data contradicts this! Aqueous binders show **stronger adhesion**

Table: Quantitative Binder Comparison

Property	PVDF	PAA	CMC	Alginate
Solvent	NMP	Water	Water	Water
Adhesion (N/cm)	~1.0	~1.5	1.1-1.7	~2.0
Modulus (MPa)	600-4000	~8000	1000	119-500
T_g	-35°C	106°C	186°C	—

The Reason: Hydrogen Bonding

Aqueous binders (PAA, CMC) are rich in **-COOH** & **-OH** groups → form strong H-bonds with oxide layers. PVDF relies on weaker van der Waals forces.

The Silicon Anode Solution

PVDF Fails for Silicon

Too stiff & brittle to accommodate $>300\%$ volume expansion

PAA: The Enabling Binder

Polyacrylic Acid (PAA) is the binder of choice for Si-anodes:

- Unique combination: **high stiffness** (~ 8000 MPa) + **elasticity**
- Can withstand & accommodate extreme mechanical stresses
- Higher concentration of carboxylic acid groups $\rightarrow$ stronger Si bonds
- Lower electrode swelling (7.49%) vs. SBR (9.56%)

The Aqueous Processing Challenge

pH Control is Critical:

- Alkaline slurries (pH ~ 12) corrode aluminum current collector
- Solution: Add acid to titrate pH to 9-10 (safe range)

The Future: Evolving PVDF's Role

Gel-Polymer Electrolytes

PVDF-HFP copolymers:

- Ideal host for liquid electrolyte
- Matrix swells, trapping liquid → "gel"
- Flexible, non-leaking "solid"
- High ionic conductivity: 10^{-4} to 10^{-3} S/cm
- NCM811 cells: 204 mAh/g, 88% retention

Composite Solid-State Electrolytes

Problem: Ceramic SSEs are brittle, poor electrode contact

Solution: PVDF as flexible polymer matrix hosting ceramic particles

- Good processability & flexibility
- Excellent electrode compatibility
- High conductivity: 4.25×10^{-4} S/cm
- Wide window: >4.6 V

Sodium-Ion Battery Incompatibility

PVDF Fails in Sodium Systems

Fundamental electrochemical instability in Na-based systems

The Failure Mechanism

- 1 During sodiation, PVDF undergoes chemical decomposition
- 2 Produces fluoride ions (F^-)
- 3 $F^- + Na \rightarrow$ forms stable, insulating **NaF layer**
- 4 Resistive layer destroys binding ability
- 5 High resistance $\rightarrow$ rapid cell failure

Conclusion

PVDF's LIB success **does not translate to SIBs**. CMC/PAA required for Na-ion batteries.

Market Size & Growth

Driven by EV & grid storage:

- **2024:** US\$ 5.99 Billion
- **2033:** US\$ 28.75 Billion
- **CAGR:** 20.3%

Market Segmentation:

- Binder application: **34.13%** of revenue
- Homopolymer: **68%** market share
- APAC region: **56.67%** (China dominance)

Key Players:

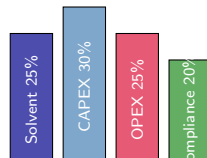
- Arkema (Kynar®)

The Real Cost Problem

Polymer price: \$7-26/kg (industrial)

Total Cost of Ownership:

- 1** NMP: 50-150× more than water
- 2** CAPEX: Massive solvent recovery system
- 3** OPEX: High-energy drying process
- 4** Compliance: Environmental & health laws



The PVDF Paradox

The Entrenched Incumbent

Unmatched Advantages:

- **0-5 V electrochemical window**
uniquely suited for high-voltage cathodes
- **Ideal rheology in NMP** enables
efficient large-scale manufacturing
- Backbone of current EV battery
production

The Fatal Flaws

Four Fundamental Problems:

- 1 **Processing:** Toxic, expensive NMP
- 2 **Recycling:** HF gas hazard
- 3 **Si-anodes:** Mechanically incompatible
- 4 **Na-ion:** Chemically incompatible

PVDF is simultaneously essential and obsolescent

Future Research Outlook: Three Paths Forward

Path 1: "Greening" PVDF

Preserve performance, eliminate NMP

- Validate & scale green solvents (DMSO, DMI)
- Develop direct recycling processes
- Create closed-loop system

Path 2: "Replacing" PVDF

Accept limitations, develop functional replacements

- Design superior aqueous binders (PAA, Alginate)
- Stronger adhesion via H-bonding
- Enable silicon anodes with mechanical flexibility

Path 3: "Evolving" PVDF

Leverage unique properties for new applications

Conductive Electrolytes (CEEs)

Key Takeaways

- 1 Crystallinity is the master property:** 32% crystallinity $\rightarrow$ 9 $\times$ adhesion, 82% vs. 64% retention
- 2 NMP is the real cost driver:** 50-150 $\times$ more than water, plus infrastructure costs
- 3 Aqueous binders have superior adhesion:** PAA $\sim$ 2 N/cm vs. PVDF $\sim$ 1 N/cm
- 4 PVDF fails for next-gen systems:** Too brittle for Si ($>300\%$ expansion), unstable in Na-ion
- 5 Future is application-specific:** Aqueous for manufacturing, PVDF for advanced electrolytes
- 6 Market is booming:** \$5.99B (2024) $\rightarrow$ \$28.75B (2033), 20.3% CAGR

Thank You

Questions and Discussion

All content derived from comprehensive PVDF research report